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Resilient assessment in the age of AI: authentic design and the case for verbal examinations in business education

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ABSTRACT

Generative AI tools such as ChatGPT challenge traditional assessment in higher education, raising concerns about academic integrity and the validity of learning outcomes. This conceptual paper examines how business schools, where written assignments are common, can redesign assessment to remain resilient as AI tools proliferate. Drawing on Wiggins' theory of authentic assessment, it conceptualises 'resilient assessment' as tasks that mirror real-world challenges and require demonstrable understanding in forms less easily replicated by AI. Verbal and interactive assessments, including oral examinations and presentations, are proposed as examples that both deter AI-assisted misconduct and develop transferable professional skills. The paper outlines a framework for implementing these practices at scale in business education and discusses policy and pedagogical implications. It concludes that developing resilient assessment should be a priority across higher education, with business schools well positioned to lead assessment innovation.

KEYWORDS

Resilient assessment;
GenAI; academic
integrity; higher
education policy

Introduction

The emergence of increasingly capable generative artificial intelligence (AI) tools is forcing universities to re-examine how learning is delivered and assessed. The public release of ChatGPT in late 2022 marked a tipping point, enabling students to produce plausible essays, reports, and case analyses and raising widespread concern about academic integrity (Zhang, Amos, and Pentina 2025). Unlike earlier forms of plagiarism, AI-generated text is unique to each prompt and therefore substantially harder to detect (Zhang, Amos, and Pentina 2025). Student use of generative AI for coursework has increased sharply; one UK survey reported usage rising from 53% to 88% of undergraduates in under a year (Brumby et al. 2025). This has intensified concern that take-home assignments and online examinations can be

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completed by AI rather than students, with implications for the credibility of higher education qualifications (Dosumu et al. 2025).

This challenge is particularly acute in business schools, where written reports, case analyses, and essays are staple assessment methods. These tasks align with practical reasoning and communication goals, yet they are precisely the kinds of outputs AI can now replicate with striking fluency (Terwiesch and Mollick 2023). If AI tools can perform well on these assessments, they expose a vulnerability in assessment design. The ease with which students may use AI to bypass learning has therefore been characterised as an academic integrity crisis (Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway 2024; Kofinas, Han-Huei Tsay, and Pike 2025), especially given the accessibility of on-demand support compared with contract cheating services (Brumby et al. 2025).

Although generative AI has prompted institutional responses, these have often lacked urgency (Moore and Lookadoo 2024). Universities have updated academic integrity policies, frequently by prohibiting or regulating AI use in assessments (Losekoot 2025), while some have advocated a return to invigilated handwritten examinations as a means of AI-proofing assessment (QAA, 2023). Such responses risk reversing progress in assessment diversity and accessibility and sit uneasily with workplace expectations that graduates will be competent users of AI tools (Brumby et al. 2025). Alternative assessment approaches that are resilient to AI are therefore urgently required.

This paper examines how business schools might develop assessment practices resilient to generative AI, drawing on authentic assessment theory with a focus on verbal assessment methods. Building on Wiggins (1990) conception of authentic assessment as evaluating learning through meaningful, real-world intellectual tasks, the paper argues that resilience depends on assessments that require students to construct, perform, and defend understanding. Verbal assessments, including viva voce examinations, presentations, and interactive discussions, are proposed as authentic, performance-based approaches that are especially resistant to AI-enabled cheating because they require students to articulate and defend understanding in real time rather than submit a polished artefact (Brumby et al. 2025). The paper first examines threats posed by AI to traditional assessment formats in higher education, with particular reference to business education. It then introduces authentic assessment theory and conceptualises ‘resilient assessment’. Verbal assessments are explored as a strategic response, followed by a framework for implementation and discussion of implications for policy, pedagogy, and academic integrity.

AI technologies and the challenges they pose to traditional forms of assessment

AI tools pose a significant challenge to conventional assessment in higher education (Ofusori and Hendradi 2025), as they can generate written content on demand that is often difficult to distinguish from human-produced work. For students inclined to cheat or cut corners, such tools make it easy to produce essays, problem solutions, or computer code without engaging in the learning process, thereby bypassing the cognitive work involved in drafting and developing

ideas (Spindel and Ackerman 2025). Many traditional formats, such as essays responding to generic titles, routine problem sets, or analyses of well-known models, can now be completed with minimal human input (Ofusori and Hendradi 2025). Studies show that AI-generated responses can achieve passing grades or better; for example, ChatGPT solved a Wharton MBA examination question with a correct and well-explained answer judged worthy of full credit (Terwiesch and Mollick 2023). Although AI performance remains uneven across tasks, these findings highlight an uncomfortable reality: many current assessments no longer reliably distinguish a well-prepared student from a well-prompted AI (Spindel and Ackerman 2025).

Business school assessments are particularly vulnerable to AI for several reasons. They frequently rely on open-ended tasks, such as case studies, essays, reflections, and reports, that require synthesis and recommendation, precisely the kinds of outputs large language models are designed to produce (Terwiesch and Mollick 2023). In addition, knowledge in areas such as management, marketing, and finance is widely available and often lacks a single correct answer, making it easier for AI to generate plausible arguments (Picciano 2024). The result is a heightened risk that students may rely on AI to undertake much of the cognitive labour of assessment, bypassing key learning processes (Brumby et al. 2025; Spindel and Ackerman 2025). As Kofinas, Han-Huei Tsay, and Pike (2025: 2) observe, *'GenAI has enabled students to complete higher education assessments quickly and with good quality, leading to challenges in academic integrity'*, allowing work to resemble learning without the learning itself having occurred.

Those responsible for academic conduct report an increase in cases of AI misuse, though many cases raised by faculty rest on suspicions rather than hard evidence, making resolution difficult (Losekoot 2025; Ojala 2025). Unlike contract cheating, where a different writing style or a purchased essay may be detected, AI use often leaves no trace. In response, universities have updated honesty policies to classify undisclosed AI assistance as misconduct, hoping clear rules deter misuse (Losekoot 2025). Others divide tasks into categories where AI is either permitted or prohibited. For instance, University College London (UCL 2025) adopted a three-tier framework: (1) AI prohibited, (2) AI assistive (akin to students using a calculator or spelling aid), and (3) AI integral (requiring work with AI outputs). Such policies clarify expectations but, as critics observe, cannot by themselves prevent students from using AI to shortcut the learning process (Spindel and Ackerman 2025).

The fundamental issue is that prevailing assessment formats were not designed with AI in mind (Head and Willis 2024). They assume that the student producing the work has also done the thinking; an assumption that no longer reliably holds (Ofusori and Hendradi 2025). As a result, educators and sector bodies are calling for a rethinking of assessment design. The UK's Quality Assurance Agency warns that reverting to handwritten examinations would be regressive, undermining authenticity and skills relevance (QAA, 2023). Instead, there is growing advocacy for diversified assessment methods that prioritise demonstrable understanding over polished written output (Casey 2024; QAA, 2023), particularly supervised, verbal, and practical assessments requiring students to demonstrate knowledge in real time (De Leon Evangelista 2025; Salinas-Navarro et al. 2024).

Authentic assessment as resilient assessment in the AI era

Authentic assessment has gained prominence as an alternative to more traditional forms of testing. Wiggins (1990) defines it as the direct examination of performance on worthwhile intellectual tasks that require students to apply knowledge to real-world challenges, producing outputs with practical relevance. This contrasts with traditional assessments that rely on proxy tasks, such as multiple-choice tests or decontextualised essays, from which the student's understanding must be inferred (Tomas 2014). Authentic tasks, including research activities, debates, or live briefings, mirror the complexity of real-life situations and require the integration of skills and knowledge rather than rote memorisation (Quinlan, Sellei, and Fiorucci 2025; Wiggins 1990). Research also links authentic assessment to greater engagement and improved academic integrity, as meaningful and relevant tasks encourage effort and reduce incentives for dishonest shortcuts (Quinlan, Sellei, and Fiorucci 2025). For example, Sotiriadou et al. (2020) found that assessments closely aligned with real-world scenarios were associated with lower misconduct and higher student engagement. Authenticity therefore serves a dual purpose, aligning assessment with meaningful learning outcomes while also discouraging shortcuts in the learning process.

The rise of AI requires us to refine what authenticity means in assessment. Early responses to tools like ChatGPT often urged 'more authentic assessments' on the assumption that AI would struggle with creative, open-ended tasks (Salinas-Navarro et al. 2024). This is partly true. Drawing on personal experiences or local data may be harder for AI. Yet evidence shows AI can also handle ostensibly authentic tasks (Jiwon et al. 2025). Kofinas, Han-Huei Tsay, and Pike (2025) found that even on assessments designed to be authentic, markers could not reliably detect AI influence, and authenticity levels had no significant effect on prevention. Thus, a real-world scenario analysis may still be credibly produced by AI. The key insight is that authenticity in task design alone is insufficient; if the mode of submission remains an asynchronous written report, AI can generate plausible answers. Authenticity must therefore extend to how students demonstrate learning, not only to the task itself.

Building from the above this paper proposes the concept of '*resilient assessment*' to describe assessment designs that maintain their integrity and educational purpose in the face of AI. Resilient assessments, under this conception, are those that (1) require a *process or performance* that is inherently tied to the student's personal effort, thus making it hard to outsource the production of the work to AI without detection, (2) remain *authentic* in that they reflect real-world applications of knowledge, and (3) include measures to *verify genuine understanding*, not just the 'appearance' of a correct answer. The goal of resilient assessment is to ensure that completing the work necessitates active engagement from the student. An example of this could involve a project whereby students may use AI tools as part of the process, thus embracing their presence and developing the ability to use these tools productively, but must then explain and justify their results orally or *via* a live demonstration, thereby proving their understanding.

Wiggins (1990) framework remains instructive here, arguing that assessment should '*require students to be effective performers with acquired knowledge*' (Wiggins

1990: 1). In an era of rapidly advancing AI, this implies more than producing polished written answers; students must be able to discuss, adapt, and apply knowledge in real time. Whereas traditional tests often measure recognition or recall (Wiggins 1990), resilient authentic assessments evaluate whether students can apply knowledge in context and explain their reasoning. In this sense, resilient assessment extends rather than replaces authentic assessment theory by ensuring that authenticity remains robust against new opportunities to game the system. One practical approach to resilient assessment design is to combine written work with verbal verification. Students might submit an essay or project and then participate in a brief viva contributing to the final grade. Such verbal examinations can confirm authorship and understanding (QAA, 2023), as students must explain how they developed their work and justify their reasoning. Although not new (Carless 2002), this approach reframes assessment as a dialogue that strengthens accountability and learning (Brumby et al. 2025). Given their long-standing role in university assessment, including doctoral defences (Carless 2002; Houston and Lunt 2024; Pearce and Lee 2009), verbal assessments offer a practical means of reinforcing authentic learning in business education.

Verbal assessments as a resilient practice within business education

Verbal assessments, broadly defined, require students to respond to questions or discuss material in real time, typically with a tutor or panel of examiners (Carless 2002; Pearce and Lee 2009). Examples include traditional viva voce examinations which may be one-on-one discussions or panel interviews where students answer questions about their knowledge (Houston and Lunt 2024), verbal presentations followed by Q&A, and more interactive oral formats such as scenario-based role plays (Kalanlar and Akkaya 2024). Stephenson, Jackson, and Wilkes (2024) note that viva examinations have been common in parts of university education, for instance within the doctoral process, and there is nothing necessarily new about the format of this assessment. Written examinations and coursework have, however, become a dominant form of assessment within universities, and business schools in particular, due to the need to handle growing class sizes. However, it can be argued that the pendulum may be swinging back. In the face of AI and other threats to integrity, some institutions are revisiting verbal assessments as a way to directly observe student learning and reasoning (De Leon Evangelista 2025).

A key argument for verbal assessment in an era of rapidly advancing AI is that misconduct is far harder in live, interactive settings. In supervised verbal examinations, students cannot simply copy answers or consult chatbots, and assessors can probe understanding through follow-up questions requiring clarification or justification (Cassidy 2024; De Leon Evangelista 2025). If responses have been generated or memorised from AI outputs, gaps in understanding quickly emerge when students must explain their reasoning in a live setting. Verbal assessments therefore allow assessors to gauge genuine understanding more effectively than static written tasks (De Leon Evangelista 2025). Evidence supports this: the University of South Australia replaced traditional examinations in several modules with structured verbal assessments and reported no breaches of academic conduct rules (Cassidy 2024). Such

formats require students to engage in unscripted discussion, reducing reliance on AI-generated responses and helping ensure that successful students meet the intended learning outcomes (Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway 2024; Kofinas, Han-Huei Tsay, and Pike 2025).

From a pedagogical perspective, verbal assessments offer benefits beyond resilience to misconduct, particularly in business education. Graduates are expected to communicate effectively, persuade others, and respond spontaneously in professional contexts such as meetings or pitches (Jackson 2014). Verbal assessments therefore align closely with key business competencies and provide a more authentic measure of these skills than written tasks alone (QAA, 2023; Wiggins 1990). Evidence supports this view. At the University of Sydney, interactive verbal assessments simulated workplace scenarios in which students adopted professional roles and discussed issues as they would with clients or executives, with participants reporting higher engagement and career relevance (Casey et al. 2024; Casey et al. 2024). However, verbal assessment also raises concerns regarding scalability and fairness (Pearce and Lee 2009). Such formats can be resource intensive, particularly when implemented as individual viva examinations (Mariano et al. 2024). Questions of equity may also arise, as non-native speakers or students prone to anxiety may be disadvantaged if performance reflects communication fluency rather than subject mastery (Doosti and Safa 2021; Iannone and Simpson 2015). These concerns highlight the importance of careful design and mitigation strategies, which the following section addresses.

Structured formats and rubrics

Verbal assessment must not be an unstructured interrogation of a student. As discussed above fairness is a key issue (Iannone and Simpson 2015) and therefore it is crucial that tutors utilise a set of questions or scenarios, potentially with some randomisation, alongside clear rubrics to facilitate grading (Gonsalves and Lin 2025; QAA, 2023). There is precedent for Business educators to draw from in this domain, with medical subjects making use of Objective Structured Clinical Examinations (Brock et al. 2003; Kantar 2025). These assessment formats are designed to evaluate the clinical skills and competence of a student in a simulated environment. They typically involve a series of timed ‘stations’ where students are asked to perform a range of tasks, being assessed by an examiner in real time (Brock et al. 2003). In these situations, as is the case with other live assessments having two examiners present, or recording the session for moderation, can enhance objectivity and mitigate bias (QAA, 2023).

Preparation

To alleviate student anxiety and to help build and practice the skills needed, students should be given full information about the assessment format, and the opportunity to engage in formative activities to ‘road test’ the assessment before summative tasks occur (Iannone and Simpson 2015). In the example from Sydney Business School mentioned previously in this section, tutors incorporated significant preparatory activity including mock verbal assessments with students as a formative activity (Casey

et al. 2024). The individuals involved in this assessment found that these preparatory activities assisted in decreasing student anxiety and improving performance (Casey et al. 2024). These activities also help to level the playing field for those less confident in spoken English or formal presentations (Iannone and Simpson 2015).

Accommodations and alternatives

When implementing verbal assessments, institutions must provide reasonable accommodations for students with documented learning differences, including speech impairments, severe anxiety, deafness, or significant language barriers (Gillies 2013). Adjustments may include extended time, pre-recorded responses followed by live questioning, or the presence of a trusted other who supports, but does not participate in the assessment (Brumby et al. 2025). The aim is to verify understanding without disadvantaging students for factors unrelated to their subject mastery (Gillies 2013).

In summary, verbal assessments offer a compelling example of resilient and authentic assessment in an era of rapidly advancing AI. They require students to demonstrate learning through explanation and dialogue (De Leon Evangelista 2025), a format in which reliance on unauthorised AI assistance is difficult (Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway 2024; Kofinas, Han-Huei Tsay, and Pike 2025). By aligning with real-world communication skills (Jackson 2014), they add value beyond safeguarding academic integrity and can enhance the relevance of the educational experience. While concerns around scale and fairness are frequently cited (Iannone and Simpson 2015; Mariano et al. 2024; Pearce and Lee 2009), these challenges are manageable through careful design, policy support, and appropriate workload resourcing. The next section builds on these insights by proposing a framework for implementing verbal assessment in business education.

A framework for the implementation of verbal assessment in business education

Designing an assessment framework that diverges from current norms in business education requires rethinking both what is assessed and how it is assessed. This paper proposes a multi-component framework for verbal assessment intended to reduce opportunities for AI-enabled shortcuts (Brumby et al. 2025; Spindel and Ackerman 2025). The framework draws on principles of authentic assessment (Wiggins 1990), lessons from recent implementations of verbal assessment in universities (e.g. Casey et al. 2024), and the need for feasibility in real-world classroom settings. It comprises seven elements: (1) task design, (2) integration of verbal components, (3) scaffolding and preparation, (4) examiner training, (5) inclusivity and flexibility, (6) scalability, and (7) AI ethics. Each is discussed in turn.

Task design

Assessment design should begin by aligning tasks with real-world business challenges (Sotiriadou et al. 2020). Rather than generic essays or examination questions, verbal

assessments must use scenarios, case studies, or projects reflecting workplace complexities (Casey et al. 2024). For example, students might act as consultants analysing a failing organisation or develop a marketing strategy within defined constraints. Grounding assessments in ‘*worthy intellectual tasks*’ relevant to business practice (Wiggins 1990: 1) encourages deeper learning while making AI-generated responses less sufficient. Authentic tasks can also increase student engagement and reduce incentives to cheat by emphasising meaningful work (Sotiriadou et al. 2020).

Integration of verbal components

Tutors must integrate verbal components into assessment design rather than adding them as an ad-hoc response to AI concerns. Depending on the module/course, this may include interview-style examinations discussing submitted work, formal presentations to a class or panel, or interactive assessments (Kalanlar and Akkaya 2024) similar to Objective Structured Clinical Examinations used in medical education (Brock et al. 2003; Kantar 2025), for instance where students must engage in an activity such as a role-play (e.g. pitching to a client or briefing a CEO on a problem). These verbal elements should be structured to probe students’ reasoning and understanding directly (Carr and Sun 2022). For example, after submitting a written business plan, potentially developed with AI support, students might be required to defend their decisions and explain how they would respond to challenges or new information. The key principle is that verbal assessment is embedded within the design of the task rather than added post hoc as a safeguard against plagiarism or AI misuse.

Scaffolding and preparation

To maximise success and minimise stress, verbal assessments should be scaffolded with preparatory activities. Tutors might incorporate low-stakes exercises such as discussions, mock interviews, or micro-presentations to build the skills required for the format. Clear guidance and rubrics should also be provided so students understand the criteria on which they will be assessed (Gonsalves and Lin 2025), which is particularly important when students are unfamiliar with the format (Fraile, Gil-Izquierdo, and Medina-Moral 2023). Practice activities, such as mock verbal examinations or interactive review sessions, allow students to experience the format before summative assessment. For example, in the Sydney Business School project, in-class activities familiarised students with interactive verbal assessments and improved both confidence and performance (Casey et al. 2024). Allowing supportive materials, such as a one-page brief or key data, can further make the assessment resemble realistic professional practice rather than a memory test. Such scaffolding helps ensure the assessment evaluates genuine understanding rather than performance under unfamiliar conditions.

Examiner training

Tutors require training to ensure fair and consistent judgement in verbal assessments, particularly where evaluation involves practical or interactive tasks. Consistency is

essential not only for fairness but also for student confidence in the legitimacy of the assessment process (Solem et al. 2024). Training should form part of continuous professional development in higher education, with organisations such as AdvanceHE well placed to support universities in developing practical guidance. Recording verbal assessments, with appropriate consent and institutional approval, can support moderation and review of contested grades (Solem et al. 2024), addressing concerns about subjectivity (QAA, 2023). Reliability can also be strengthened through the involvement of multiple assessors, for example, through joint assessment, shadowing arrangements, or the inclusion of external industry professionals to provide an additional perspective.

Inclusivity and flexibility

Where verbal assessments are used it is important that faculty consider how accommodations and choices can be built into the assessment format to ensure inclusivity. For students anxious about oral communication or for whom English is a second language (Iannone and Simpson 2015), it is important to design the assessment setting thoughtfully, for instance undertaking the verbal assessment on a one-to-one basis in a quiet room, instead of in front of an audience. Accommodations might include allowing a student to submit a pre-recorded video presentation followed by a short live Q&A to reduce the pressure of a full live verbal examination. The goal of the verbal assessment is to verify understanding rather than undertaking interrogation and therefore a conversational tone is key (Brumby et al. 2025). As the QAA advises (QAA, 2023), faculty must have safeguards for vulnerable students and be mindful of biases, not disadvantaging those who are communicating in a second language, or who may have other barriers to communication fluency (Doosti and Safa 2021). It is important that such issues are considered ahead of time otherwise the consequence could be that the verbal assessment could introduce new inequities or barriers to participation or performance.

Scalability

From an administrative perspective, verbal assessments require careful planning to mitigate challenges associated with scalability, particularly within large programmes. This may involve staggering assessments over several days, running parallel sessions (either in person or online), and drawing on additional faculty, postgraduate researchers, or other qualified assessors where necessary to support assessment periods. When structured appropriately, verbal assessments can be distributed across teaching teams rather than resting solely with module leaders, which could make them manageable within resource constraints, although this then requires extensive assessor training and calibration and discussed already in this section. The use of digital platforms for scheduling, video conferencing, and recording can further streamline logistics and support quality assurance processes such as moderation and review (Mariano et al. 2024; Pearce and Lee 2009).

In larger programmes, verbal assessment may also be deployed strategically rather than universally. For example, it may be concentrated in selected modules, such as

capstone courses, major projects, or assessments where verifying individual understanding is particularly important in meeting learning outcomes. Targeted integration allows Business Schools to realise the pedagogical and integrity benefits of verbal assessment without requiring wholesale replacement of all written assessments. Verbal elements can also be incorporated into existing assessment structures, such as project presentations, reflective discussions, or structured questioning following submission of written work, thereby embedding verification of understanding (QAA, 2023) within established teaching and assessment practices.

Creative timetabling and the use of technology can further support scalability (Mariano et al. 2024). Although where assessments are spread over time an added variable is introduced to the assessment whereby candidates sitting the assessment later may have an undue advantage through information shared by earlier candidates (Pearce and Lee 2009). Careful question design and allocation through the use of structured question banks and individualised prompts, can mitigate against unauthorised information sharing. Through such measures, verbal assessment can be implemented in ways that remain pedagogically robust, fair, and operationally sustainable across groups of varying sizes. Scalability of this assessment method is, however, noted as a significant challenge.

AI ethics

Resilience to AI does not mean ignoring it; universities must prepare students to use such tools effectively in employment (Brumby et al. 2025). The proposed framework therefore allows assessments where AI is permitted or required, provided tasks still demand critical human engagement. For example, students might use AI for literature searches, data analysis, or draft feedback, while a verbal component requires them to demonstrate understanding in real time (Carr and Sun 2022; Casey 2024; QAA, 2023). Tutors may also ask students to reflect on their AI use, such as how it was employed or what challenges arose, encouraging transparency rather than covert misuse (Losekoot 2025; Ojala 2025). By integrating AI openly, business schools can assess students' ability to use technology responsibly, an important workplace competency (Basheer, Bui, and Jarrett 2024). In this way, resilience is achieved not by excluding AI but by requiring its use to be explicit and critically evaluated (Sotiriadou et al. 2020; Spindel and Ackerman 2025).

Discussion: implications for policy and practice

Adopting resilient, authentic assessment practices, particularly verbal assessments, in business education has implications beyond classroom practice, extending to institutional policy and culture. These implications can be considered across three dimensions: policy (including administrative and accreditation considerations), pedagogy, and academic integrity systems. Implementing verbal assessments at scale will first require policy support, thoughtful design, and appropriate resource allocation (Mariano et al. 2024; Pearce and Lee 2009). As outlined in the framework proposed in this paper, scalable models can be achieved through structured formats, parallel delivery, and strategic integration within programmes, but sustainable

implementation depends on institutional backing. Regulations may need updating to permit verbal assessments beyond contexts such as doctoral examinations (Houston and Lunt 2024), while AI policies must evolve accordingly (Losekoot 2025). Rather than blanket bans, institutions should encourage responsible AI use so graduates develop skills valued by employers (Basheer, Bui, and Jarrett 2024; Brumby et al. 2025). Policies emphasising student ownership and demonstrable understanding (Carr and Sun 2022; Casey 2024; QAA, 2023) may help deter misconduct, although frameworks alone cannot eliminate malpractice (Spindel and Ackerman 2025). Accreditation bodies are also responding: AACSB has identified academic integrity risks associated with AI as a major concern in business education and noted that many schools lack actionable guidance (AACSB 2025). The framework proposed here contributes to addressing this gap while supporting assurance standards.

The shift towards more authentic assessment methods, such as conversations and verbal examinations, will reshape teaching and learning practices (Head and Willis 2024). Faculty development will therefore be essential. Staff accustomed to lectures and traditional assessments may find interactive formats challenging due to greater demands on interpersonal skills and concerns about subjectivity in grading (Doosti and Safa 2021). Targeted professional development can support staff in areas such as questioning techniques, time management in verbal examinations, and evaluating spontaneous responses (Kantar 2025). Despite these challenges, vivas and similar assessments often receive positive feedback, with instructors valuing the opportunity to engage directly with students and observe their thinking rather than relying solely on written work (Carless 2002; Pearce and Lee 2009).

For students, greater use of verbal and authentic assessments can reshape the learning experience (Head and Willis 2024). These formats emphasise understanding rather than memorisation or last-minute essay writing (Carr and Sun 2022; Casey et al. 2024), requiring students to engage continuously and apply knowledge in discussion (De Leon Evangelista 2025). Although some may initially find this challenging, such discomfort can support a growth mindset and lead to stronger real-world skills with appropriate teaching support (Basheer, Bui, and Jarrett 2024; Burnette et al. 2023). While accessibility considerations remain important (Gillies 2013; Iannone and Simpson 2015), verbal assessments are particularly valuable in business education, where many learning outcomes focus on communication, teamwork, and problem-solving, skills often better demonstrated through discussion than traditional written tasks.

From the perspective of academic integrity and culture, redesigning assessment to prevent shortcuts (Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway 2024) shifts the focus from policing misconduct to preventing it through meaningful learning. Rather than relying on detection tools such as plagiarism checkers or AI scanners, which are often unreliable in practice, assessment can be designed so that authentic performance is the default expectation (Kofinas, Han-Huei Tsay, and Pike 2025). When students must demonstrate understanding through verbal interaction, they are encouraged to take ownership of their learning, fostering an ‘integrity’ rather than compliance mindset. Although no assessment method is foolproof (Deakin University 2025), verbal assessment can form part of a broader integrity strategy alongside student contracts, guidance on the ethical use of AI, and clear sanctions for

misconduct (Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway 2024). Implementing such approaches also has implications for institutional support, including scheduling systems, recording tools, and the responsible use of AI in supportive roles such as generating individualised cases or question variants. Institutions should enable responsible experimentation with these tools where they support authentic learning rather than shortcuts. Finally, student engagement remains essential; while learners often value assessments with real-world relevance (Basheer, Bui, and Jarrett 2024), transparent communication, opportunities for practice, and the sharing of positive examples can help address initial anxiety around verbal assessment formats.

Conclusion

The advent of AI in education is often portrayed as an arms race between the detection mechanisms that universities can deploy and the ability and/or desire of students to shortcut the learning process (Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway 2024; Dosumu et al. 2025; Zhang, Amos, and Pentina 2025). This paper argues for a different response involving a pedagogical and policy shift towards resilient authentic assessment (Wiggins 1990) that upholds academic integrity and educational quality by design, rather than relying on after-the-fact detection. In the context of business education, this paper has identified verbal forms of assessment, guided by the theory of authentic assessment (Wiggins 1990), as a powerful tool in redesigning assessments for a time in which AI is advancing at a rapid pace (Casey 2024; De Leon Evangelista 2025; QAA, 2023; Salinas-Navarro et al. 2024). Authentic tasks assessed verbally compel students to engage deeply with content and demonstrate their understanding in real time (Brumby et al. 2025; Carr and Sun 2022), making it considerably more difficult to delegate their learning to an AI tool (Casey 2024; Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway 2024; Kofinas, Han-Huei Tsay, and Pike 2025). As Wiggins (1990: 1) might observe, such assessments demand that students be ‘*effective performers*’ of their knowledge, not just be able to recall information. They shift the focus of evaluation from what has been written (which an AI can do) to what is understood (which only the student can show) (Brumby et al. 2025; Carr and Sun 2022).

Literature and emerging practice support this approach. Authentic assessments, including interactive vivas, can deter misconduct while developing employability skills (Sotiriadou et al. 2020). Trials such as the University of South Australia’s replacement of written examinations with vivas suggest that well-designed assessments strengthen confidence that grades reflect genuine learning (Cassidy 2024). Challenges remain, particularly scalability and fairness, but the framework proposed here shows how verbal assessments can be implemented sustainably through structured formats, parallel delivery, and strategic use within programmes. Its success depends on treating assessment as a shift towards students actively demonstrating knowledge (Brumby et al. 2025; Carr and Sun 2022; Casey 2024; QAA, 2023), supported by training, clear criteria, and appropriate accommodations (Iannone and Simpson 2015). In doing so, it also aligns assessment with employer expectations of business graduates, including the ability to analyse complex problems, and communicate effectively (Basheer, Bui, and Jarrett 2024).

For higher education policy, especially in quality assurance and accreditation (AACSB 2025b), this paper offers a clear message; innovation in assessment must be incentivised and supported, as maintaining the status quo is untenable in the face of AI. Policies that fostered reliance on easily graded but vulnerable formats should be reconsidered (Ofusori and Hendradi 2025; Terwiesch and Mollick 2023) and replaced with guidelines promoting diverse approaches, including verbal and performance-based assessments. Business schools, often early adopters of new pedagogies, can lead this shift. Grounding assessment in genuine intellectual performance and dialogue strengthens learning against AI-generated shortcuts, with benefits across stakeholder groups. First students gain deeper skills, secondly, faculty trust grades as valid indicators of ability and finally, employers gain confidence in the preparation that graduates have received. Though experimentation and resources will be required, the reward is a resilient system that withstands technological disruption while advancing authentic, high-integrity education.

Limitations and further research

While this paper foregrounds verbal assessment, it is not proposed as a standalone solution; resilient assessment strategies must be multifaceted. Timed in-class tests retain value for assessing foundational knowledge, though their authenticity is limited (QAA, 2023), while project-based learning, portfolios, and programmatic assessment can also support integrity by requiring sustained, personalised effort (Cotton, Cotton, and Shipway 2024; Kofinas, Han-Huei Tsay, and Pike 2025). The argument here is simply that verbal formats deserve greater emphasis in business education, where they align closely with programme goals (Basheer, Bui, and Jarrett 2024). Their effective use also depends on assessor capability, and faculty may require support through shared guidance, communities of practice, and pilot initiatives (Pearce and Lee 2009). Although AI impersonation in verbal examinations currently appears unlikely due to the interactive nature of dialogue-based assessment (Brumby et al. 2025; Pearce and Lee 2009), particularly in face-to-face settings (Brock et al. 2003; Kantar 2025), institutions should remain alert to technological developments that may create new opportunities to bypass learning.

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